

Party Identification in the Age of Obama: Evidence on the Sources of Stability and Systematic Change in Party Identification from a Long-Term Panel Survey

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Abstract

Political scientists have long disagreed about the nature of individual-level change in party identification. While some scholars conclude that party identification is a stable identity—attributing changes in individual responses to measurement error—others show that aggregate party identification responds systematically to short-term forces such as presidential approval. In this article, we use a unique long-term panel measuring party identification twenty times in the 2011–2016 period to support a subtle compromise between these competing claims. We show that individual-level party identification changes systematically over time even after accounting for measurement error and that this change is related to short-term evaluations of the parties and the president. However, although such change exists, it is modest in the medium term and more common among specific subsets of respondents. Finally, we show that these findings are robust to numerous alternative modeling strategies. We believe that our analysis provides the most systematic examination to date of individual-level changes in party identification.

Keywords

party identification, panel data, presidential approval

Introduction

The nature of party identification change is the subject of one of the longest running, most prominent debates in the study of American political behavior. The argument that party identification is a stable, social psychological, affective phenomenon is a central feature of The American Voter and the Michigan School of political behavior (Campbell et al. 1960). In contrast stand accounts that treat party identification as a dynamic cognitive phenomenon that is influenced by short-term political forces.

In this article, we leverage data from The American Panel Survey (TAPS), which asked the standard party identification (PID) battery twenty times over the 2011–2016 period, to reexamine these questions and provide a clearer answer about the nature of party identification. A panel interviewed on such a frequent basis over such a long period of time—nearly the entirety of President Obama’s second term—provides an unprecedented look at party identification in the United States. Moreover, TAPS included monthly questions evaluating the parties, presidential job performance, and views on the state of the economy, which allows us to assess the relationship

between moving political evaluations and party identification. In all, these data give us a fresh and powerful basis for reevaluating long-standing arguments about the nature of party identification change.

We take advantage of the uniquely rich data from TAPS to support three hypotheses. First, we show that party identification changes systematically at the individual level even after accounting for measurement error and autocorrelation. This finding directly contradicts several previous accounts that treat changes in party identification as artifacts of the survey process. Second, we find that shifts in party identification are associated with individuals’ changing evaluations of the two major parties and appraisals of the president. We believe that our analysis is the most comprehensive study to date demonstrating a direct link between evaluations of the

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political environment and changes in party identification at the individual level. Third, despite the evidence of systematic change in individual-level identification, we also demonstrate that party identification remains stable for certain individuals. In particular, we show that change in party identification is less common among African Americans and negatively associated with age and familial socialization. Finally, in "Alternative Analyses: Possible Endogeneity" section and our online appendices, we show that these findings are robust to a number of alternative modeling strategies.

In all, our study concludes that while party identification is remarkably stable and persistent for many voters, it is not the "unmoved mover" as it is sometimes characterized in the literature, where changes occur only during periods of political instability (i.e., "realignments"). Neither, however, does party identification fluctuate fluidly in response to every political event. Instead, we argue that party identification changes at the margins in response to short-term political forces, but that this change is gradual and restricted to individuals with less entrenched partisan identification. That is, party identification is a reflection of individuals' present evaluations of the political environment and changes meaningfully during periods of normal politics to reflect citizens' evaluations of current events and the political environment. Yet, changes are neither rapid nor universal, occurring gradually and primarily among individuals whose background and circumstances fail to reenforce their partisan social identity.

Central Questions About Party Identification

The social psychological concept of party identification has its origins in some of the earliest work on political behavior (e.g., Lazarsfeld, Berelson, and Gaudet 1944). In this view, party identification is a social identity developed in early life experience, is internalized through socialization, biases perceptions of the social world, and has a lasting effect on the political attitudes of many, if not most, people (Hyman 1959; Mannheim 1952). This understanding was extended in *The American Voter*, which treats party identification as an indicator of a psychological attachment—a social identity—that biases the processing of information about candidates, issues, events, and vote choice (Campbell et al. 1960). This process generates a "persistent adherence" to a party that, while not immutable, stabilizes partisan preferences over a lifetime. Further studies directly confirmed that party identification is transmitted (if imperfectly) from generation to generation as a social identity. In particular, the Niemi and Jennings studies (e.g., Jennings and Niemi 1981) measure party identification of both parents and children in interviews conducted in 1965, 1973, 1982,

and 1997 and show the transmission of party identification as a social identity through familial socialization.

In contrast stand various theoretical accounts that treat responses to party identification as a more fluid concept: an affective attachment that responds to the flow of political events and reflects changing views of the two major parties, the economy, and the president. Various theoretical accounts in this PID-as-dynamic-attitude camp, with origins dating as far back as Downs (1957) and Key (1966), argue that short-term political forces readily influence party identification (see also Achen 1992; Fiorina 1981). For instance, aggregate data suggest that party identification at the national level moves systematically in response to events such as recessions and wars (MacKuen, Erikson, and Stimson 1989). Economic performance, consumer sentiment, and crucial political events all predict changes in aggregate-level party identification, which suggests (but does not prove) that individual-level partisan identity responds to these factors as well.

The debate between these competing camps on the nature of party identification is vast and rich, and no one study is capable of arbitrating between all of the available theories. (Indeed, it is not clear that there truly is a single analysis that could put this longrunning debate to rest.) Nonetheless, we believe that the unique granularity of the TAPS survey, which measures party identification twenty times over the course of four and a half years, justifies reexamining some of the central questions in the literature: (1) Does party identification change? (2) Does party identification change in response to short-term political evaluations? and (3) What are the sources of individual-level heterogeneity in party identification stability?

One of the central questions in the literature has always been about the scope and even the existence of meaningful party identification change. Broadly speaking, between 41 and 48 percent of respondents to the American National Election Study panels, the inevitable source of data in this debate, stay within the same partisan categories (Clarke and McCutcheon 2009). Fiorina (1981) interpreted these patterns as demonstrating that party identification is quite unstable and, therefore, that the party identification is a moving evaluation (see also Allsop and Weisberg 1988; Jackson 1975; Jackson and Kollman 2011).¹

In contrast stand the studies summarized in Green, Palmquist, and Schickler (2002) that, using nearly the same data, conclude that party identification is a stable identity. These studies argue that survey responses involve a random component, which, left uncorrected, upwardly biases estimates of partisan instability. For instance, Green and Palmquist (1990) show that uncorrected wave-to-wave correlations for the 1980 ANES (American National Election Study) panel range from .85 to .89, which implies moderate partisan instability. However, error-corrected correlations are .98, which

implies near perfect stability, and the small effects of short-term forces evaporate when estimates of party identification are corrected for measurement error.

Green and Palmquist (1994) extend this argument to the other ANES panels, but, noting that the balance of Democrats and Republicans changes over time in the aggregate (MacKuen, Erikson, and Stimson 1992), they concede that shifts in party identification may occur. They propose that political forces may alter aggregate party identification by shifting responses uniformly in the population, thus changing mean partisanship without changing rank order of respondents. Yet, their central argument remains that “only when measurement error is ignored does one obtain results that micropartisanship [individual-level party identification] moves in response to short-run political conditions” (Green and Palmquist 1994, 457), a claim echoed in later reports (e.g., Green, Palmquist, and Schickler 2002, 69).

In all, this work does not claim party identification never changes (e.g., Green, Palmquist, and Schickler 1998, 896). Over time, confronted with clear evidence of macro-level movement in response to short-term factors, the disagreement between these camps narrowed to the size of relationships rather than its mere existence. Nonetheless, we think it is fair to summarize this stream of work as supporting a traditional view of party identification that is unresponsive to all but the most dramatic and sustained forms of political stimuli. In this view, individual-level change in party identification in survey data is mostly a methodological artifact allowing them to conclude that “we are aware of no statistical studies that convincingly demonstrate that individuals’ partisan attachments are profoundly influenced by the ebb and flow of political fortune” (Green, Palmquist, and Schickler 2002, 113).

More recent studies have kept the debate alive. Clarke and McCutcheon (2009) estimate mixed Markov latent class models and find substantial variation in latent party identification in the multiwave ANES panels. About half of ANES respondents remained in the “mover” group. Dancey and Goren (2010) find that media coverage of intense issue debates that divide elite partisans can lead at least some ANES respondents to update both partisan and issue preferences. Bartels et al. (2011) offer another approach by focusing on whether change in party identification persists and whether that change is conditioned by a set of factors measured in the ANES studies. With a random effects multinomial logit model of the 1992–1996 ANES panel, they find that older changers exhibit more persistence in their new partisanship relative to younger changers, and changes in partisanship are often followed by a reversion.

A related, but separate, question is what factors produce changes in party identification. Green, Palmquist, and Schickler (2002) argue that party identification is unaffected by all but the most dramatic and sustained

political stimuli (e.g., the civil rights realignment in the South). In contrast, Erikson, MacKuen, and Stimson (2002) show that evaluations of the country’s economic performance shape views of the two parties, with good economic news increasing support for the president’s party (see also Fiorina 1981; Kinder and Kiewiet 1981). Fiorina (1981) argues that party identification reflects a “running tally” of affective associations with each party related to evaluations of recent events. Other studies make the argument that presidential job approval ratings are a good barometer of national attitudes toward the president’s party and so serve as a good proxy for short-term political forces. For instance, Jacobson (2012) demonstrated the connection between aggregate partisanship and presidential approval in recent presidencies, while Ghitza and Gelman (2014) demonstrate that presidential approval affects party identification quite strongly in the formative years.

Finally, past work also has looked for individual-level traits that condition the amount of partisan change we should expect. Jennings and Niemi (1981) specifically argue that party identification is less stable for younger voters (see also Dinas 2014) and that stronger childhood socialization contributes to stability. In addition, Erikson, MacKuen, and Stimson (2002) show that African Americans have a particularly strong attachment to the Democratic party that is relatively impervious to events in the economic or political world (see also Bowler, Nicholson, and Segura 2006).²

Our theoretical standpoint is that both dominant accounts in the literature are correct, but incomplete. First, we argue that individual-level party identification does, in some cases, change in response to short-term political forces. The evidence in support of this contention at the aggregate level is too overwhelming to be a coincidence. Given appropriate data, we believe that responsiveness to short-term political forces should be observable at the individual level as well. Thus, our primary empirical expectations are as follows:

Hypothesis 1: Individual-level party identification changes over time even after accounting for measurement error and autocorrelation, and this change is a function of short-term evaluations of the parties, the president, and the economy.

Yet, it is important to realistically circumscribe these claims. Past research shows that party identification change is neither ubiquitous nor universal. For many individuals, party identification is an important social identity that is resistant to external political forces. In some cases, party identification changes in response to factors in the political environment, but this does not refute the evidence presented by Green, Palmquist, and Schickler (2002) showing that identification is a

remarkably stable trait for most people most of the time. That change happens does not imply that it is either dramatic or even common. Indeed, previous studies point to several specific individual-level factors that we expect to constrain party identification change. In particular, past research shows that party identification is more stable among older individuals whose social identities are more strongly established and individuals who experienced strong early-life familial socialization.

Furthermore, party identification is reinforced by other group identities. This has been found to be particularly true for African Americans and the Democratic party. Since the passage of civil rights legislation in the 1960s, black voters have consistently identified as Democrats in high numbers (Dawson 1994). Thus, we expect black panelists to exhibit less partisan change than white and Latino counterparts.

Hypothesis 2: Younger adults will have increased levels of change in party identification.

Hypothesis 3: Strength of familial partisan socialization is negatively related to change in party identification.

Hypothesis 4: Racial and ethnic identities that are consistent with partisan identity decrease the amount of change in party identification.

Data and Method

To test these hypotheses, we use data from TAPS, a monthly long-term panel study that has asked the standard party identification battery twenty times over the course of four and a half years. Relative to the ANES panels or the Youth–Parent Socialization Panel Study, TAPS has the advantage of more frequent measurement of party identification. Moreover, its duration is roughly equal to that of one ANES panel interval (four years). This unprecedented combination of long duration and high frequency allows us to better distinguish systematic change from nonsystematic measurement error.

TAPS also provides us an opportunity to examine party identification change in more diverse political contexts. The vast majority of ANES panel waves are conducted in the immediate run-up or aftermath of presidential or congressional elections, a context when partisan ties may be more salient. TAPS waves, on the contrary, occur both during periods of electoral frenzy and more mundane periods when Election Day is far off.

Finally, TAPS includes a monthly battery evaluating time-varying factors hypothesized to affect party identification, including self-reported views of the economy, affect toward each of the parties, and evaluations of the president. It also includes an extensive battery of questions about early-life familial socialization and other factors thought to affect party identification stability.

TAPS itself is a monthly online panel that was initially recruited as a national probability sample with an address-based sampling frame in the fall of 2011 by GfK Knowledge Networks. Individuals without Internet access were provided a laptop and Internet service at no cost. In a typical month, about 1,700 of the panelists complete the online survey. Our focus is on the twenty waves where party identification was measured, which are shown in online Appendix A along with sample sizes for each wave.³

Importantly, the sample is divided into two groups, with one half receiving a presidential job approval battery and the other half receiving a consumer confidence battery. Each group alternates from month to month so that every panelist receives both batteries in any two-month period. For some items, we combine responses from waves measuring party identification with the previous wave where that item was asked to obtain measure the most proximate prior evaluations. Additional details about the split-panel design are provided in online Appendix A. Response rates are discussed in online Appendix G.

Variables

The dependent variable in all of our analyses is the standard ANES measure of party identification. Responses are coded on a seven-point scale ranging from *strong Democrat* (1) to *strong Republican* (7). We follow previous studies by operationalizing party identification as a seven-point continuous variable (e.g., Green, Palmquist, and Schickler 2002).⁴

We measure short-term forces in three ways. First, following Fiorina (1981) and Jacobson (2012), we use the standard presidential approval measure. Second, we build a measure of respondents' differential evaluations of the two parties, which we use to test the theory that a "running tally" of evaluations of the two parties affects party identification (Achen 1992; Fiorina 1981). Specifically, we used questions on job approval for "Washington Democrats" and "Washington Republicans," each measured on a five-point scale. In our analyses, we use the difference in these evaluations, which we refer to as net party evaluations. Third, to measure prospective sociotropic evaluations of the economy, panelists are asked about whether economic conditions in the country are getting better or worse.

We cannot match the Jennings–Niemi studies' direct measure of parents' party identification or the corresponding measurement of high school students' identities. We instead rely on the panelists' reports of their own party identification at 18 years of age. We use the three-category response: Democrat (–1), Republican (1), and Independent (0). Furthermore, we created a binary variable indicating the strength of early-life familial socialization, where we

coded socialization as high for individuals whose party identification at age 18 matched both of their parents' party identification.

Finally, we include measures of demographic traits that may condition party identification change. In our statistical models, we treat race and ethnicity as a dichotomous indicator identifying panelists as either "white" or "non-white." However, when examining factors that influence stability, we break this variable down further, dividing the sample into Hispanic, black, and white subpopulations. Similarly, we include a control for gender with a dummy variable coded "1" for female panelists. For our stability models, we also divide respondents by age (above 55 years vs. below 55 years). Finally, in the autoregressive latent trajectory models, we employ categorical measures for education and household income, where the baseline categories represent those who do not have a high school diploma and household incomes less than \$30,000, respectively. All question wordings and coding schemes are provided in online Appendix M.

Autoregressive Latent Trajectory Models

Our objective in selecting a statistical approach was to characterize respondents' underlying party identification after removing short-term variations in response due to measurement error. The specific models we implement below are variants of the autoregressive latent trajectory models, which were designed precisely for the task of measuring changes in an underlying latent trait in panel data (Bollen and Curran 2005; Curran and Bollen 2001). See Torres and Smith (2018) and Boston et al. (2018) for recent applications of autoregressive latent trajectory (ALT) models in political science.⁵

ALT models are essentially a multilevel hierarchical model specifically designed for common issues in panel data (see Curran 2003, for more on the equivalence of multilevel models and structural equation models in this setting). The simplest version assumes that party identification is a latent variable (measured with error) that follows a linear trend. For individual $i \in [1, N]$ at time period $t \in [1, T]$, we model party identification (y_{it}) as, $y_{it} = \alpha_i + \lambda_t \beta_i + \epsilon_{it}$, where $\epsilon_{it} \sim N(0, \sigma)$ are iid errors, and α_i and β_i are random intercepts and slope terms. The standard approach is to constrain $\lambda_t = [1, 2, \dots, T]$.⁶ In this simplest example, therefore, party identification for individual i is modeled as a perfect line, $y_{it} = \alpha_i + \beta_i t + \epsilon_{it}$ with an individual intercept and slope. Note that an alternative notation would be, $y_{it} = \gamma_t \alpha_i + \lambda_t \beta_i + \epsilon_{it}$, where γ_t represents the degree to which the α_i constant affects y_{it} . Standard practice in this literature is to constrain $\gamma_t = 1 \forall t \in [1, \dots, T]$ for identification.

This simple model—assuming that the trajectories of party identification are exactly linear—is obviously extremely limiting. Following Bollen and Curran (2005),

therefore, we make two fundamental adjustments. First, we allow for an autoregressive term such that party identification in period t can be correlated to party identification at time $t - 1$ even after accounting for a general linear trend in the data. Crucially, we do not assume that this autoregressive process is constant across time; we allow that the autoregressive process to be estimated for each period.⁷ Second, we allow for heterogeneous error rates in each time period, $\epsilon_{it} \sim N(0, \sigma_t)$, such that we estimate a separate error variance term (σ_t) for each period. Together, these assumptions accommodate significant deviations away from strict linearity assumption in the trajectories of latent party identification. Finally, in an autoregressive model such as this we need to take additional steps to model party identification in the initial period ($t = 0$). Following Bollen and Curran (2005), we take the agnostic approach of simply allowing for correlated errors between this baseline party identification measure, the individual random constants (α_i), and slopes (β_i).

The basic ALT model, termed an unconditional univariate ALT model, is shown in Figure 1. Formally, this can be written as

$$\begin{aligned} y_{it} &= \alpha_i + \lambda_t \beta_i + \rho_{y_i, y_{i-1}} y_{i,t-1} + \epsilon_{it}, \epsilon_{it} \sim N(0, \sigma_{y_t}) \forall t \neq 0 \\ \alpha_i &= \mu_\alpha + \zeta_{\alpha i}, \\ \beta_i &= \mu_\beta + \zeta_{\beta i}, \\ y_{i,t=0} &= \mu_{y_{i=0}} + \zeta_{y_{i=0}} \end{aligned} \quad (1)$$

$$\begin{pmatrix} \zeta_{\alpha i} \\ \zeta_{\beta i} \\ y_{i,t=0} \end{pmatrix} \sim N(0, \Sigma),$$

where μ_α , μ_β , and $\mu_{y_{i=0}}$ are the estimated means for the distribution of individual constants, slopes, and initial measurements, respectively. Furthermore, we assume that the error terms for these variables are jointly normal with covariance matrix Σ . Alternatively, this could be denoted

$$\begin{pmatrix} \alpha_i \\ \beta_i \\ y_{i,t=0} \end{pmatrix} \sim N \left(\begin{pmatrix} \mu_\alpha \\ \mu_\beta \\ \mu_{y_{i=0}} \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} \Sigma_{\alpha\alpha} & \Sigma_{\alpha\beta} & \Sigma_{\alpha y_{i=0}} \\ \Sigma_{\alpha\beta} & \Sigma_{\beta\beta} & \Sigma_{\beta y_{i=0}} \\ \Sigma_{\alpha y_{i=0}} & \Sigma_{\beta y_{i=0}} & \Sigma_{y_{i=0} y_{i=0}} \end{pmatrix} \right).$$

Note that the numbers in Figure 1 represent the constraints on how the intercepts (α) and linear time trend (β) map onto latent party identification as discussed above. In addition, the arrows pointing into the party identification terms indicate that each wave is allowed to have a distinct error term σ_t . Finally, the $\leftrightarrow$ linking α , β , and $y_{t=0}$ indicates that we have allowed that these variables may have correlated errors.

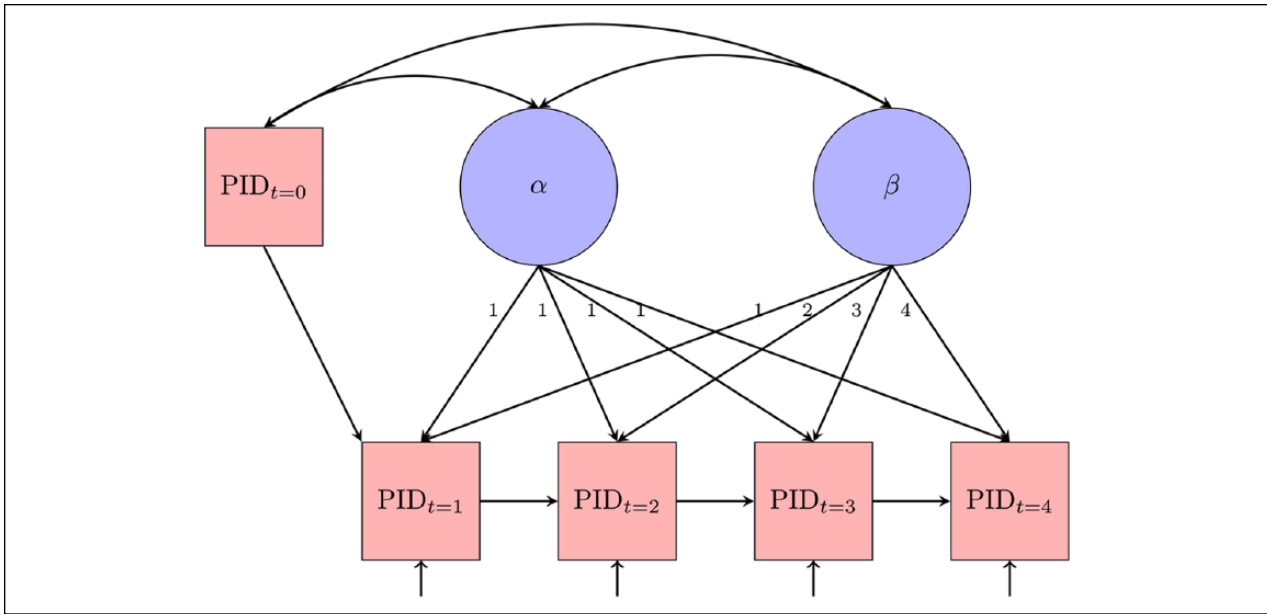


Figure 1. Unconditional autoregressive latent trajectory model for five waves.
PID = party identification.

Covariates. To test our theoretical expectations, we need to not only measure change in party identification but also to explicitly model the short-term forces associated with this change. Moreover, we wish to be able to stabilize estimates using time-invariant demographic indicators. To accommodate covariates, we fit the conditional ALT model with both time-invariant ($\mathbf{Z}_i$) and time-varying predictors ($\mathbf{X}_i$) shown in Figure 2. Specifically, we alter model 1 to

$$\begin{aligned}
 y_{it} &= \alpha_i + \lambda_t \beta_i + \rho_{y_i, y_{i-1}} y_{i,t-1} + \\
 &\quad \rho_{y_i, \mathbf{x}_{i-1}} \mathbf{X}_{i,t-1} + \epsilon_{it}, \epsilon_{it} \sim N(0, \sigma_{y_t}) \forall t \neq 0 \\
 \alpha_i &= \mu_\alpha + \gamma_\alpha \mathbf{Z}_i + \zeta_{\alpha i}, \\
 \beta_i &= \mu_\beta + \gamma_\beta \mathbf{Z}_i + \zeta_{\beta i}, \\
 y_{i,t=0} &= \mu_{y_{i=0}} + \gamma_{y_{i=0}} \mathbf{Z}_i \zeta_{y_{i=0}},
 \end{aligned} \quad (2)$$

where γ_α and γ_β are vectors of coefficients relating the vector of time-invariant predictors $\mathbf{Z}$ to the intercept and slope of the latent trajectory respectively. Further, $\rho_{y_i, \mathbf{x}_{i-1}}$ is a coefficient relating the lagged value of time-varying factors, such as presidential approval, to party identification. Note that we constrain $\rho_{y_i, \mathbf{x}_{i-1}}$, the estimated effect of lagged time-varying factors on party identification, to be constant across waves to facilitate interpretation.⁸

Findings

Our findings confirm the core thesis that party identification changes and does so in response to short-term

political forces. We report these findings in four steps. First, we show the modest aggregate change in party identification during the period under study. Second, we report that, at the individual level, panelists exhibit measurable change in party identification from wave to wave, even when accounting for measurement error. Third, we test whether the observed change in party identification is related to changes in net party evaluations, presidential approval, and economic evaluations. Finally, we confirm that the propensity to change party identification is circumscribed and that party identification stability is associated with several individual-level characteristics identified in the existing literature. In the next section, we also consider several alternative model specifications.

Stability and Change

We begin by noting that, for the most part, November 2011 to May 2016 was a stable period in American politics. This is illustrated in Figure 3, which shows mean aggregate party identification, net party evaluations, presidential approval, and economic evaluations across all twenty waves of the panel. During this period, the American economy showed gradual improvement. Gridlock on major issues and muddling through crises about fiscal deadlines characterized the policy-making arena, while Republicans retained their majority in the House of Representatives, the Democrats retained the White House, and Democrats controlled the Senate until the 2014 elections. By most measures, Congress and the

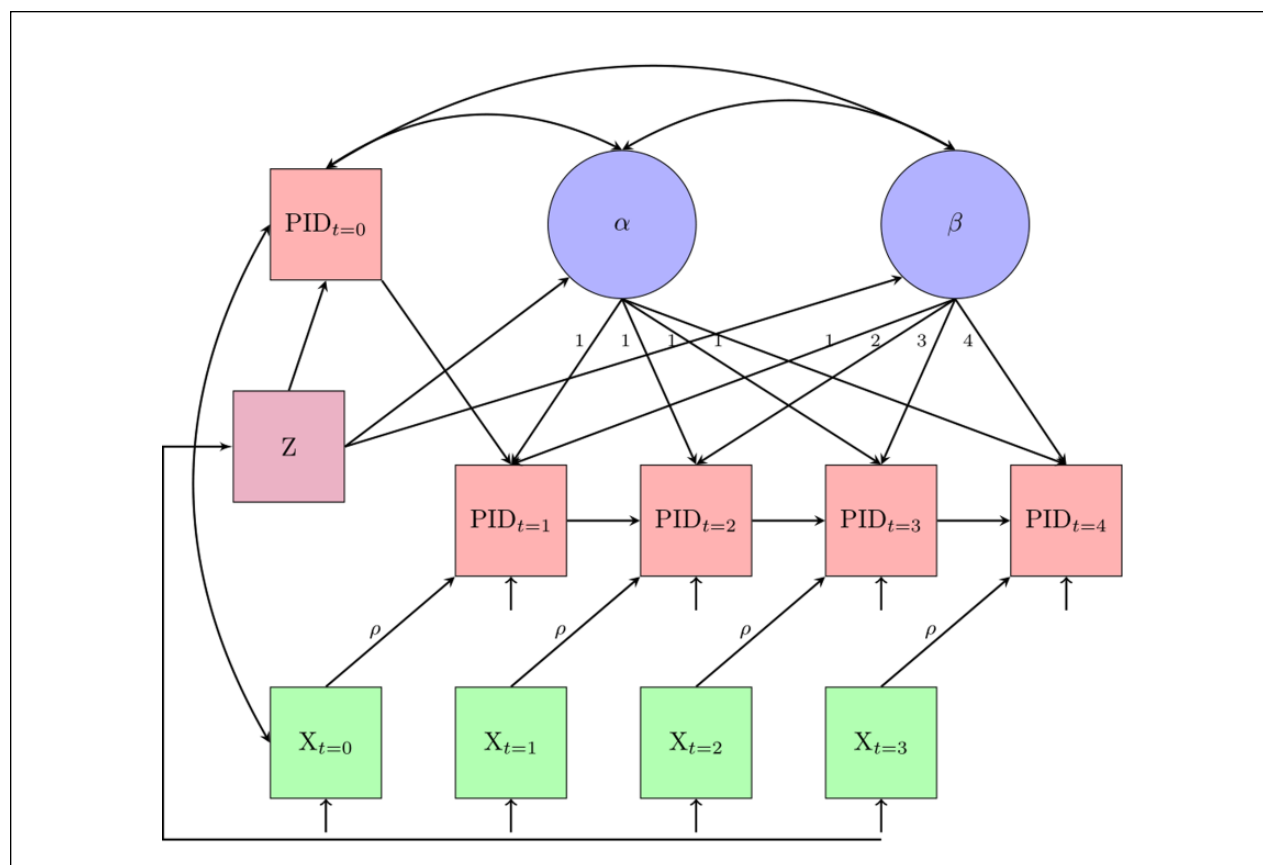


Figure 2. Conditional ALT model with both time-invariant (**Z**) and time-varying (**X**) predictors.

public showed substantial partisan polarization on major issues, a condition that had not changed much for more than a decade. Consequently, we do not see dramatic changes in party identification or in the nature of the political environment captured by our measures of short-term forces.

Nonetheless, the measures of short-term political forces exhibit more change than aggregate party identification. As in other surveys, the president's approval improved a little during the 2012 election year but dipped in the two years following his reelection. Economic evaluations show a slight positive trend over the period under study. However, in all, this is a period of stability, and we should expect relatively small effects of short-term political forces on party identification, making it more difficult to uncover systematic change.⁹ Moreover, as shown in Figure 4, this aggregate-level stability in party identification holds even when breaking down party identification by category.

Although party identification appears superficially stable, beneath the surface there is individual-level variation. Figure 5 shows individual-level party identification in each wave, where the sample has been divided based

on party identification in the pre-panel interview.¹⁰ Thus, the top-left and bottom-right panels show that strong Democrats and Republicans move little—roughly 75 percent of strong Democrats and 67 percent of strong Republicans end in the same party identification category in which they began. However, the remaining panels show that there is some significant—if fundamentally limited—movement across categories during the panel. Note that the majority of the movement is among the not-strong (weak) identifiers and leaners.

Evidence of Real Change in Party Identification

Much of the variation exhibited in Figure 5 may be random measurement error, as Green and Palmquist (1990) emphasize. That is, panelists may choose different options from wave to wave in an unintentional way without any real change in their attachment to or attitudes about the parties. It is essential that such error is taken into account when estimating the frequency and nature of change in party identification.

Thus, our first task is to determine whether the party identification of our panelists changes over time or

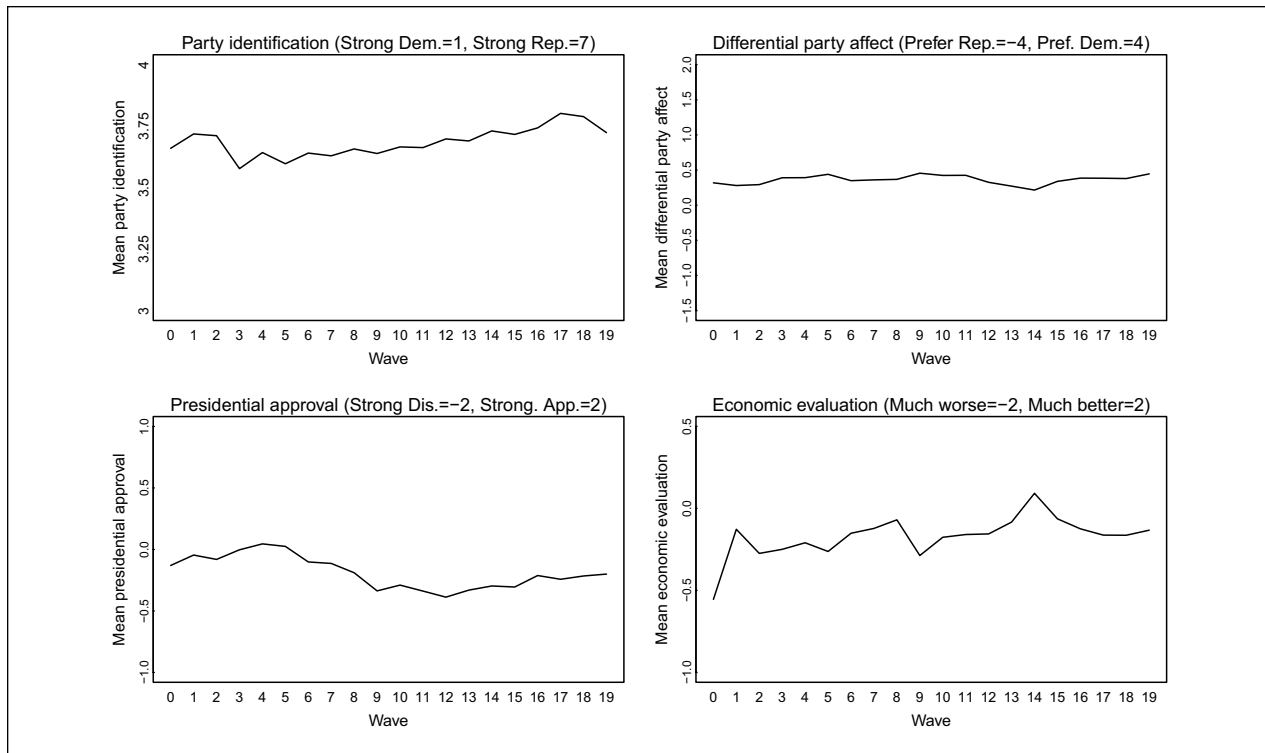


Figure 3. Aggregate trends for time-varying variables.

whether it maintains relative stability across all observable waves once we account for measurement error. Specifically, we determine whether responses merely vary at random around an unchanging constant, or whether there are instead individual-level trends in party identification over time. We estimate a model of latent partisanship by assuming the trend in partisanship over time is nonexistent ($\beta_i = 0 \forall i \in [1, N]$) and that survey responses are best conceptualized solely as variation around the individual-level constant (α_i). We then compare this model with one in which we also estimate individual-specific level trends for each respondent ($\beta_i \neq 0$). As the former model is nested within the latter, we are able to formally test whether allowing for individual-specific trends in party identification across waves significantly improves model fit.

Table 1 provides the model fit statistics and parameter estimates of an unconditional ALT model of party identification both excluding (Column 1) and including (Column 2) a trend in party identification.¹¹ In these simpler model, where we have included no covariates, we have only the hierarchical components as shown in equation (1) above. These include the means for the individual intercepts (α_i) and time trends (β_i) as well as estimates for the correlation in the errors of these terms (e.g., $\Sigma_{\alpha\gamma=0}$, the level of

correlation in errors for the individual intercepts and their reported party identification in the baseline period).

More important, the fit statistics all indicate that a model including individual-level slopes improves model fit. The comparative fit indices (CFI) and root mean square error of adjustment (RMSEA) are quite close to 1 and 0 respectively, indicating overall excellent fit. However, in both cases, the model allowing for the estimation of individual-level linear trends fits better.¹²

While the more fully specified model shows improved model fit, it is necessary to perform a significance test on the difference to determine whether allowing for trends provides additional information. We adjust our significance test using the methods recommended by Satorra and Bentler (2010) by implementing the scaling correction factor. The estimated χ^2 statistic ($\chi^2 = 141.73$, $df = 4$, $p < .001$) shows that adding individual-level trajectories significantly improves the model fit. Thus, we conclude that our panelists exhibit significant party identification change as predicted by Hypothesis 1.

To better understand this result, Figure 6 provides illustrative examples of estimated latent trajectories for four individuals as well as their observed party identification responses across all 20 waves. In

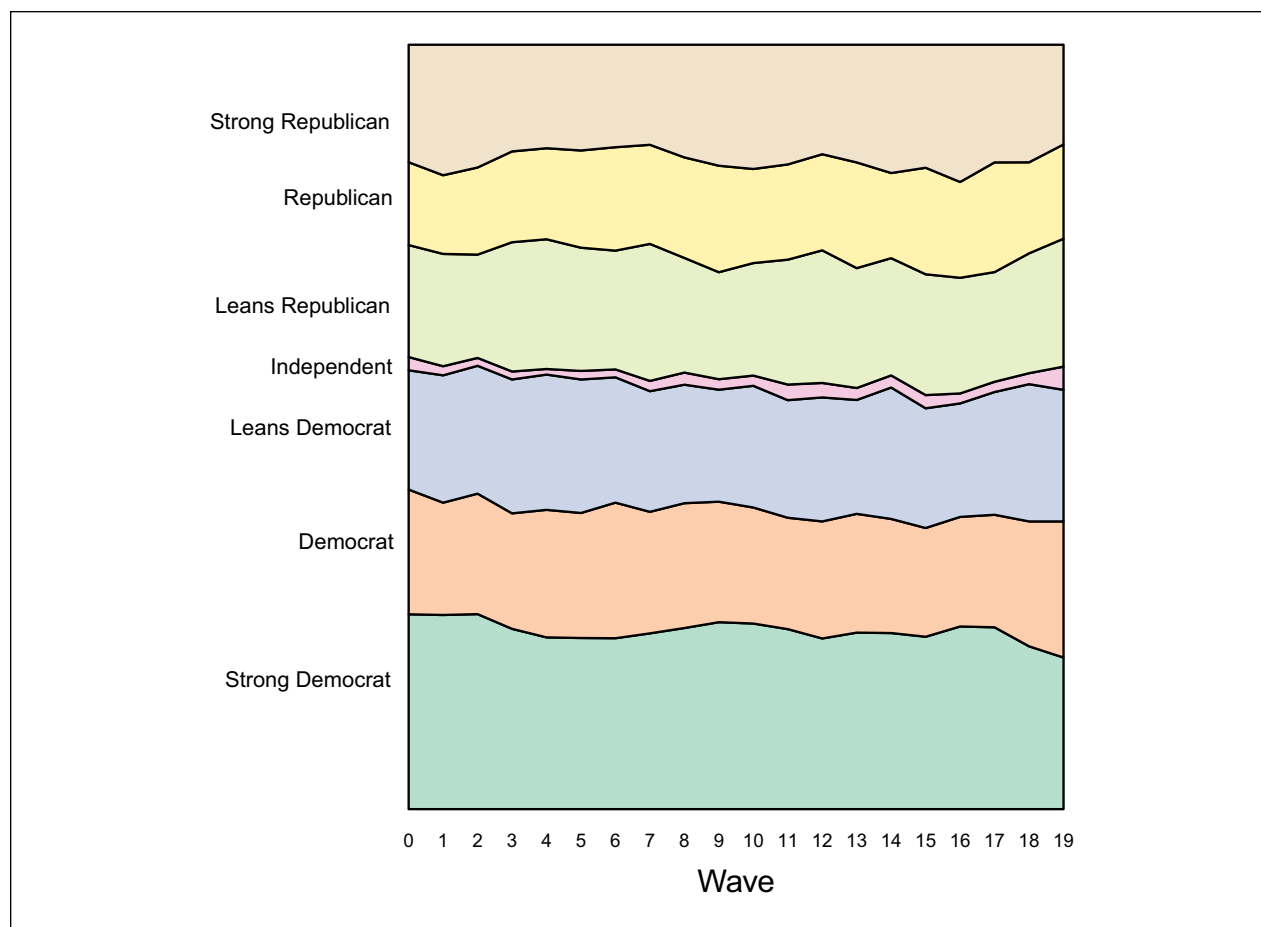


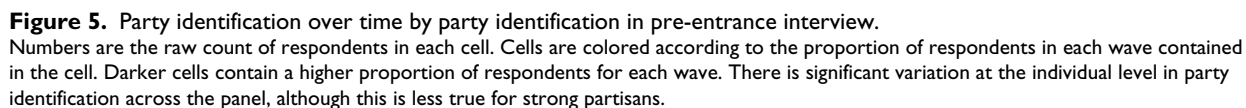
Figure 4. Aggregate trends in party identification.

particular, we chose four actual respondents whose reported party identification varied in terms of its over-time trajectory (flat vs. trending) and level of random error (high/low variability). The left panels show examples where the model provides relatively stable party identification estimates with a limited trend. The right panels show individuals for whom the model estimates change over time. The top panels are examples where observed responses are (relatively) tightly bound around the model estimate, while the bottom panels are examples where there is (relatively) more error around respondents' true positions. These examples illustrate how the ALT models discriminate between short-term random variations in party identification across waves and systematic change. Temporary movements away from a central tendency are largely ignored as measurement error; predicted values do not change much in response to temporary shifts in reported party identification.

Party Identification and Short-Term Evaluations of the Political Environment

Are individual-level changes in party identification related to individual-level evaluations of the political environment? To test this, we next fit the conditional ALT model with time-invariant and time-varying predictors shown in Figure 2. As time-invariant predictors, we include education, gender, race, income, and self-reported party identification at age 18, which primarily serve to improve estimates of individual-level intercepts. As time-varying predictors, we include lagged net party evaluations (LNPE), lagged prospective economic evaluations, and lagged presidential approval.

The primary results for this model are shown in Table 2, and critical coefficients are highlighted. They show that party identification is significantly related to LNPE ($\rho = -0.074$, $SE = 0.011$) and lagged presidential approval ($\rho = -0.075$, $SE = 0.013$). These coefficients are



evaluations of the economy do not reach reliable levels of statistical significance ($\rho = -0.017$, $SE = 0.012$).¹³

To further unpack the substantive implications of these results, we conduct a simulation experiment exploring the

Table 1. Autoregressive Latent Trajectory Models of PID with and without Linear Trends.

	Column 1 No slopes ($\beta = 0$)	Column 2 With slopes ($\beta \neq 0$)
Hierarchical component		
Mean of individual intercepts (μ_{α})	2.87* (0.125)	3.45* (0.071)
Variance of individual intercepts ($\Sigma_{\alpha\alpha}$)	2.72* (0.177)	3.87* (0.159)
Mean of slopes (μ_{β})		-0.036* (0.012)
Variance of individual slopes ($\Sigma_{\beta\beta}$)		0.002* (0.001)
Covariance of intercepts and slopes ($\Sigma_{\alpha\beta}$)		-0.055* (0.014)
Covariance of initial PID and intercepts ($\Sigma_{\alpha y_{t=0}}$)	0.371* (0.113)	-0.180* (0.082)
Covariance of initial PID and slopes ($\Sigma_{\beta y_{t=0}}$)		0.005 (0.005)
Model fit statistics		
CFI	0.965	0.986
RMSEA	0.028	0.018
χ^2	521.418	315.126
df	188	184
χ^2 difference	141.73 ($df = 4, p < .001$)	
N	2,295	2,295

Standard errors are in parentheses. PID = party identification; CFI = comparative fit indices; RMSEA = root mean square error of adjustment.

*Statistical significance at the $p < .05$ level.

effect of an exogenous shock in short-term evaluations on expected party identification for a chosen individual.¹⁴ Specifically, holding all parameter estimates constant, including estimated individual-level intercepts (α_i) and slopes (β_i), we imagine decreasing the time-varying covariate LNPE by three categories in Wave 7—a significant but realistic change in LNPE in favor of Republicans.¹⁵ We compare these results to our expectations for this same individual if we left her short-term evaluations exactly as observed. We interpret the differences in our predicted values of party identification under these two scenarios to represent the substantive effect of this hypothetical exogenous shock.

First, in Figure 7, we show the estimated effect of a temporary (one-wave) exogenous change in LNPE. That is, we simulated expected values for party identification as if this shift were a temporary single-wave phenomenon. As can be seen, such a short-term shift in LNPE temporarily alters our expectations about respondent's party identification in the next wave, but this difference is not lasting. After jumping by 0.21 categories in Wave 7, the long-term expected party identification for this individual is almost completely unaffected.

A very different story appears when we simulate under the assumption that the exogenous shock to LNPE is permanent. That is, we imagine that, beginning in wave 7, LNPE decreases three categories for the duration of the panel. Figure 8 shows that this change is associated with permanent shift in expected party identification. To begin with, we observe an increase of 0.21 categories. However, this change is then amplified by the autoregressive components of the model until the respondent reaches a level of party identification approximately 0.27 categories higher than we would have otherwise expected. As discussed below, this 0.27 category change is more than we observe for a third of panelists. Thus, this simulation illustrates that a permanent change in a respondent's LNPE has both a substantively and statistically significant effect on party identification, strongly supporting Hypothesis 1.

Evaluating the Scope of Change

Having established that changes in party identification are both real and related to theorized short-term forces, we next turn to characterizing the change in party identification we observe across our twenty waves. The most

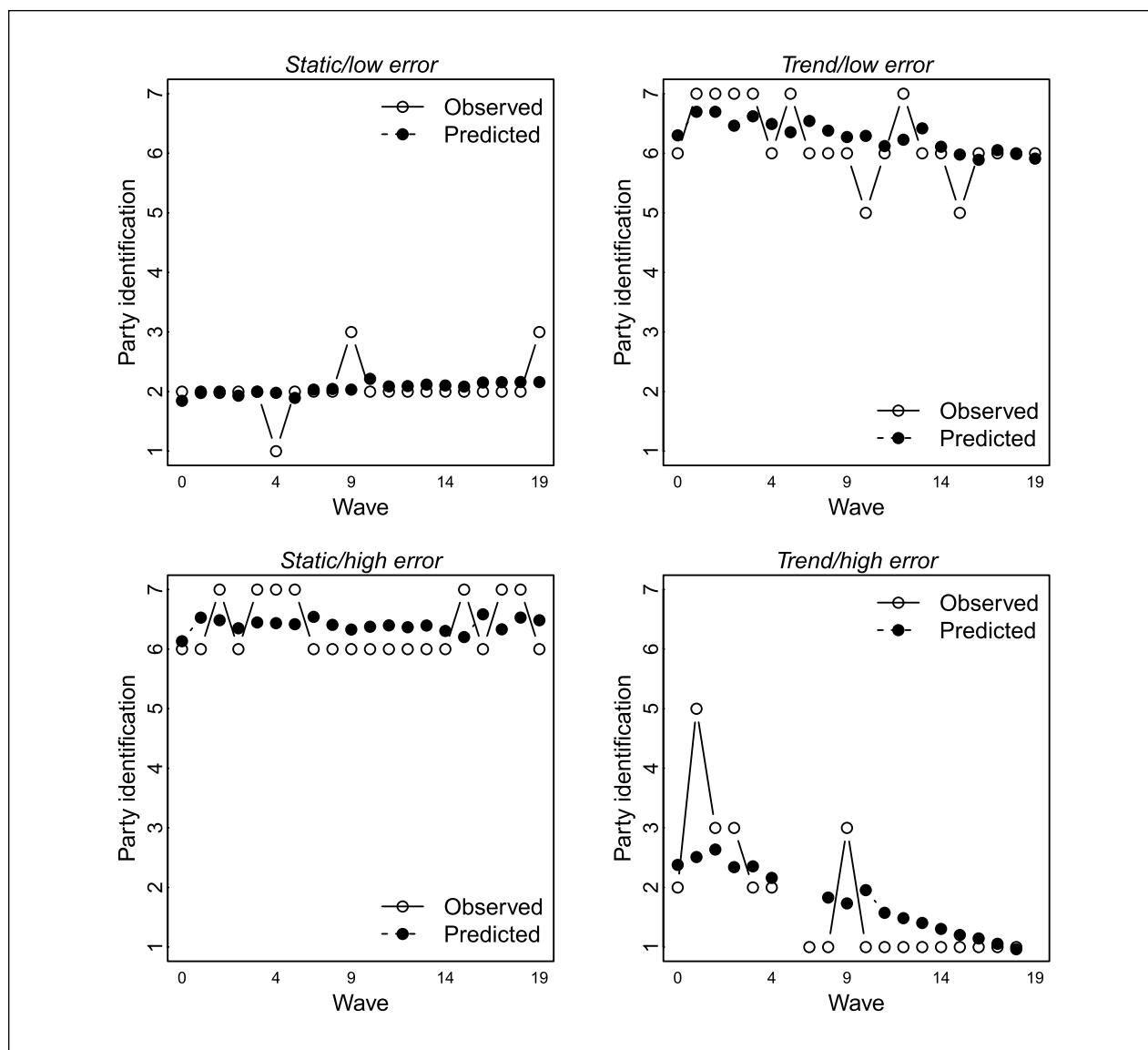


Figure 6. Exemplar individual-level latent trajectories.

Observed (solid points) and predicted (open points) party identification for four individual respondents.

obvious pattern is that for most people most of the time, party identification is a remarkably stable individual-level trait. To illustrate this point, in Figure 9, we show the change in estimated party identification for all respondents in our data set beginning from the wave where they first enter the panel. These estimates can be interpreted as the true change in underlying party identification after removing variation resulting from measurement error.¹⁶ As can be seen, although there is some substantial change for a few respondents, the vast plurality of respondents change very little.

The scope of this individual-level stability is further illustrated in Table 3. Here, we estimate the overall level of

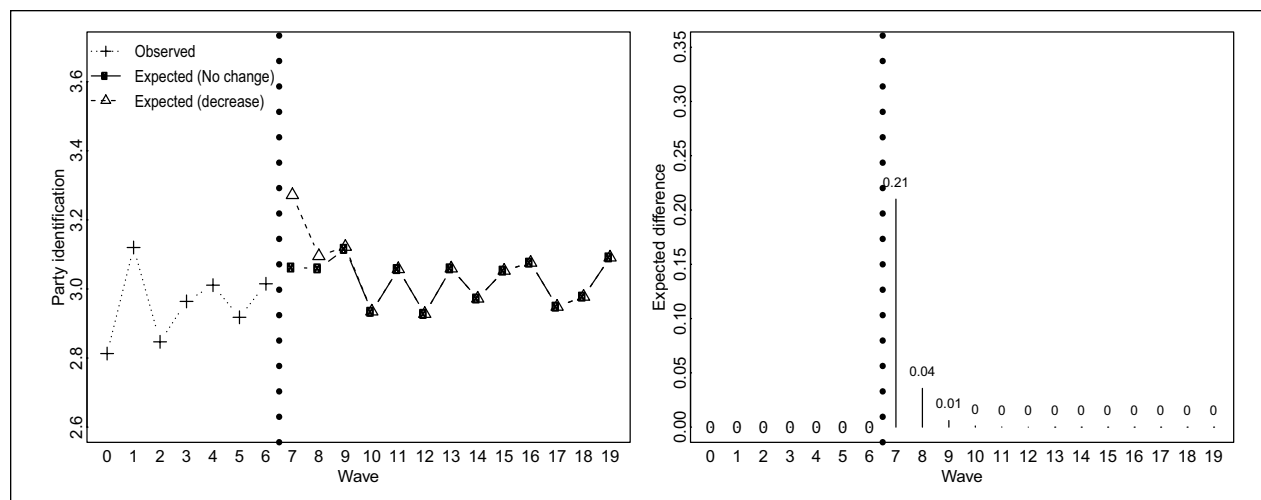
change for each respondent for whom latent party identification could be estimated in at least five waves ($n = 1,840$). Specifically, we calculated the absolute value of the difference between the maximum and minimum estimated party identification from the model for each individual. Table 3 shows that for roughly 34.5 percent of respondents, party identification was essentially unchanged (<0.25 categories) across the panel. Another 31.1 percent changed less than a half of a category. Indeed, estimated party identification changed more than a full category for only 13 percent of respondents. Thus, while we are able to demonstrate significant and explainable changes in party identification, it is important to understand these results in context.

Table 2. Determinants of Individual-Level PID: Conditional ALT Model with Time-Invariant and Time-Varying Predictors.

Time-varying predictors			
Net party evaluation _{t-1} → PID _t	-0.074*		
	(0.011)		
Presidential approval _{t-1} → PID _t	-0.075*		
	(0.013)		
Economy _{t-1} → PID _t	-0.017		
	(0.012)		
PID constant		PID slope	
Intercept	2.995*	Intercept	-0.027*
	(0.192)		(0.014)
High school diploma	0.067	High school diploma	0.005
	(0.191)		(0.013)
Some college	-0.108	Some college	0.014
	(0.166)		(0.012)
College or higher	-0.397*	College or higher	0.014
	(0.167)		(0.014)
Female	-0.127	Female	0.005
	(0.078)		(0.003)
White	0.610*	White	0.003
	(0.095)		(0.006)
\$30,000–\$59,000	0.166	\$30,000–\$59,000	0.000
	(0.118)		(0.007)
\$60,000–\$99,999	0.088	\$60,000–\$99,999	-0.003
	(0.119)		(0.007)
\$100,000 or higher	0.338*	\$100,000 or higher	-0.010
	(0.130)		(0.007)
PID at 18	1.052*	PID at 18	-0.011
	(0.061)		(0.006)
$\Sigma_{\alpha\alpha}$	1.481*	$\Sigma_{\beta\beta}$	0.001*
	(0.131)		(0.000)
CFI	0.921		
RMSEA	0.024		
χ^2	3,906.785		
df	1,473		
N	2,783		

Standard Errors are in parentheses. Autoregressive coefficients are shown in Tables SI-3 in online Appendix B. Additional model parameters are suppressed for clarity. PID = party identification; CFI = comparative fit indices; RMSEA = root mean square error of adjustment.

*Coefficients significant at the $p < .05$ level.

**Figure 7.** Simulated predicted effects of a temporary change in time-varying covariates.

A short-term three-unit decrease in lagged net party evaluations has a temporary effect on party identification for a white female respondent with some college education with a household income above \$100,000 who reported being a Republican at age 18.

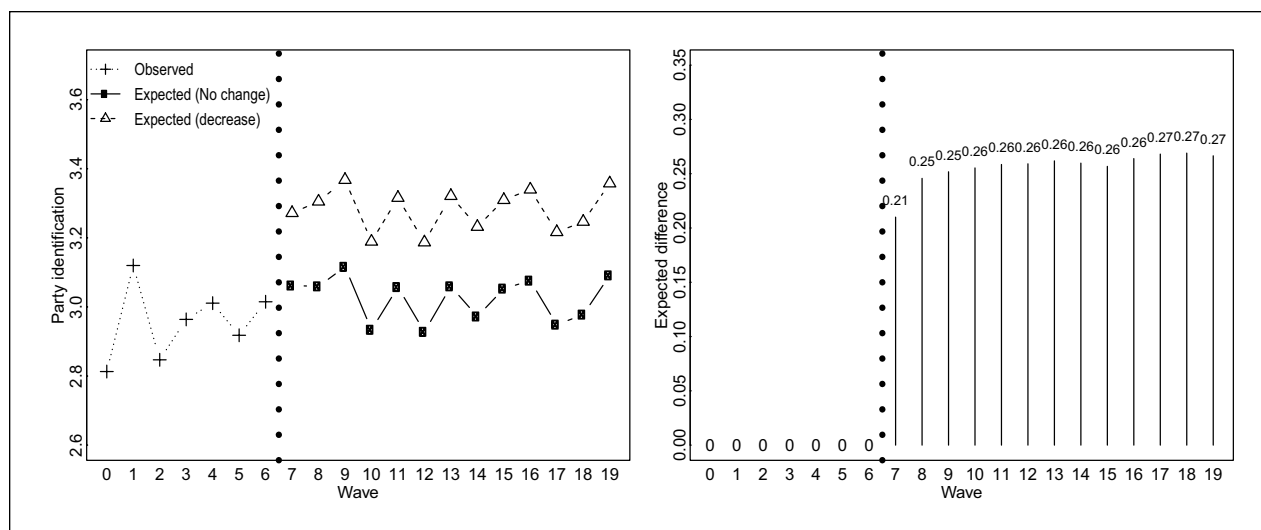


Figure 8. Simulated predicted effects of a durable change in time-varying covariates.

A long-term three-unit decrease in lagged net party evaluations has a substantive long-term change in party identification for a white female respondent with some college education and a household income over \$100,000 who reported being a Republican at age 18.

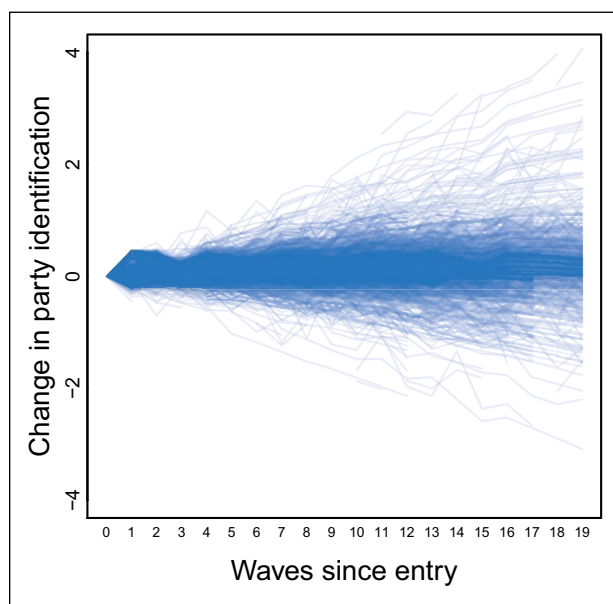


Figure 9. Latent trajectories for all respondents.

Are there important individual-level differences in party identification change as Hypotheses 2 to 4 state? To test this, we examine how the estimated change in party identification among long-term panelists differs among several subgroups, defined by time-invariant individual-level predictors.¹⁷ Specifically, we break down change by age (above 55 years vs. below 55 years), political socialization (coded as high for individuals whose ID at age 18 matched both of their parents), and race/ethnicity. The results are shown in Table 4.^{18,19}

In all cases, our expectations are met. Individuals above 55 and individuals whose party identification at age 18 matched both of their parents exhibit significantly less change in party identification than others (Hypotheses 2 and 3). Change in party identification is significantly lower for black respondents (Hypothesis 4), although there is little difference in the change of white and Hispanic respondents.

Before concluding, we note that each of the differences discussed above is statistically significant according to a Wilcoxon sign-rank test for the difference in medians, which requires no strong distributional assumptions. Furthermore, we show in online Appendix E that the conclusions above also hold in a multivariate regression analysis.

Alternative Analyses: Possible Endogeneity

In this section, we present additional analyses to test the robustness of our main findings. We confront potential endogeneity concerns and, while we cannot entirely rule these out in our observational data set, discuss results from several supplementary analyses intended to ameliorate these worries.²⁰

We argue that party identification changes as a consequence of changes in net party evaluations and presidential approval. One concern is that the correlations discussed above are spurious due to the presence of unmeasured confounders. A second concern is that we have the causal relationship backwards and it is, for instance, changes in party identification that affect changes in presidential

Table 3. Amount of Change in Latent PID among Long-Term Panelists.

Amount of change	Number	%
0–0.25	635	34.5
0.25–0.5	572	31.1
0.5–1	394	21.4
1–1.5	151	8.2
≥ 1.5	88	4.8
Total	1,840	100

Change is estimated for individual i as $|\max(\text{PID}_{it}) - \min(\text{PID}_{it})|$ $\forall t \in [1, 20]$ where PID_{it} is the estimated latent PID from the model at time t . These unweighted counts were estimated only among panelists for whom estimates could be generated for at least five waves. PID = party identification.

Table 4. Amount of Change in Latent PID among Long-Term Panelists.

Category	Median	Wilcoxon sign-rank test statistics
Race/ethnicity		
White	0.396 ($n = 1,382$)	White vs. black 148,260*
Black	0.194 ($n = 194$)	Black vs. Hispanic 10,342
Hispanic	0.398 ($n = 232$)	White vs. Hispanic 134,640
Socialization		
Low socialization	0.426 ($n = 1,273$)	Low vs. high 255,870*
High socialization	0.393 ($n = 856$)	
Age		
Below 55	0.396 ($n = 874$)	Below 55 vs. above 55 377,760*
Above 55	0.375 ($n = 972$)	

Change is estimated for individual i as $|\max(\text{PID}_{it}) - \min(\text{PID}_{it})|$ $\forall t \in [1, 20]$ where PID_{it} is the estimated latent PID from the model at time t . All group-level differences are significant ($p < .05$) according to the Wilcoxon sign-rank test for difference in medians with the exception that Hispanics are not distinguishable from whites. These unweighted analyses were estimated using only panelists for whom estimates could be generated for at least five waves. PID = panel identification.

approval. As these factors are extremely difficult to manipulate experimentally on a durable basis, we are left to evaluate these effects in an observational setting that presents serious challenges for measurement and causal inference. Nonetheless, we have taken several steps to evaluate the robustness of our findings.

To address the potential for spurious correlations due to unmeasured confounders, we estimated a standard fixed effects regression, which includes a separate constants for

all respondents to account for individual heterogeneity. Thus, it accounts for any unmeasured time-invariant confounders that might affect both the explanatory variables and party identification. Formally, this can be written as,

$$y_{it} = \alpha + \bar{\alpha}_i + \rho_y y_{i,t-1} + \rho_x \mathbf{X}_{i,t-1} + \epsilon_{it}$$

$$\epsilon_{it} \sim N(0, \sigma_{\epsilon_{it}}) \forall t \neq 0,$$

where ρ_x represents the effect of the lagged time-varying covariates (net party evaluations, presidential approval, and economic perceptions), ρ_y is the AR(1) coefficient to account for autocorrelation, and $\bar{\alpha}_i$ is the fixed effect estimated for respondent i . The results, shown in Table 5, again confirm our basic finding that changes in net party evaluations and presidential approval lead to changes in party identification.

Another approach to addressing concerns about unmeasured confounders is to adopt an instrumental variables framework (see Franklin and Jackson 1983 for a similar strategy). Specifically, we estimate the effect of current economic perceptions, presidential approval, and net party differential evaluations on party identification using an instrumental variable regression. As current period short-term evaluations may be endogenous with party identification, we instrument using lagged values. The model, which is conceptually similar to standard two-staged least squares, is

$$x_{it} = \alpha_1 + \mathbf{z}_i \gamma_1 + x_{i,t-1} \beta_1 + y_{i,t-1} \rho_1 + v_{it}$$

$$y_{it} = \alpha_2 + \mathbf{z}_i \gamma_2 + x_{it} \beta_2 + y_{i,t-1} \rho_2 + u_{it},$$

where y_{it} represents individual i 's party identification at time t , $\mathbf{z}_i$ is a vector of time-invariant covariates, and x_{it} is a time-varying covariate. For each period t , we use the lagged values of the time-varying factors ($x_{i,t-1}$) as instruments (see Wooldridge 2005). Thus, our results are based on the assumption that, for instance, net party evaluations at time $t-1$ affect party identification at time t only through net party evaluations at time t . If this assumption holds, then we can interpret the β_2 coefficients as representing the contemporaneous effect of the time-varying predictors (e.g., net party evaluations) on party identification.

The main results of these panel instrumental variable regressions may be found in Table 6.²¹ Once again, they support the conclusion that party identification is affected by presidential approval and net party evaluations.

Finally, we attempt to handle the fact that party identification likely has a reciprocal relationship with time-varying factors such as net party evaluations. To do this, we estimate a cross-lagged model similar to those estimated in Carsey and Layman (2006). Specifically, we

Table 5. Fixed Effects Model Predicting Current Period Party Identification.

Constant	3.115* (0.101)
Presidential approval _{t-1}	-0.044* (0.015)
Net party differential _{t-1}	-0.040* (0.010)
Economic evaluation _{t-1}	0.007 (0.011)
Party identification _{t-1}	0.178* (0.027)
R ²	.865
N	27,342
Groups	2,102

Clustered robust standard errors (clustered on respondent) are in parentheses. This analyses was estimated using survey weights with the xtreg command in Stata 15.

*Coefficients significant at the $p < .05$ level.

estimate the model depicted in Figure 2 but now also allow party identification at time $t-1$ to affect the time varying covariates (e.g., presidential approval) at time t . Following Carsey and Layman (2006), we also constrain the lagged effects to be the same across waves.²² Table 7 shows the estimates for both the lagged and cross-lagged effects for all covariates. Once again they support the main findings that net party evaluations and presidential approval have an effect on party identification even allowing for cross-lagged effects.²³

Conclusion

Are citizens watching the parties, keeping score in their minds, and updating their attachments in response to events? or Do citizens internalize their attachments to the parties, allowing their understandings of their selves and their worlds to take on a partisan tinge? While these are central questions in the history of the scientific study of political behavior, the answers to these questions remain unclear. As Erikson, MacKuen, and Stimson (2002) note,

The micro behavior literature fails to resolve this issue of the nature of citizen attachment to party, in particular, whether it is fundamentally based upon rational appraisals of outcomes or on "identification" in its strongest sense, a self-image of commitment to one side. (p. 15)

In this article, we exploit the unprecedented richness of TAPS to show that both the PID-as-identity and the PID-as-dynamic-attitude conceptualizations are correct for different people at different times. Using a conditional autoregressive latent trajectory model, we show that party identification does change for some individuals, and that

Table 6. Determinants of Individual-Level Party Identification: Instrumental Variable Regression.

Constant	1.161* (0.117)
Presidential approval _t	-0.145* (0.022)
Net party differential _t	-0.152* (0.018)
Economic evaluation _t	0.018 (0.019)
Party identification _{t-1}	0.723* (0.020)
Wave Fixed Effects	Yes
R ²	.866
RMSEA	0.816
N	22,188
Cluster	1,535

Clustered robust standard errors (clustered on respondent) are in parentheses. Additional controls were included for education, gender, race, income, and party socialization. Full results are shown in online Appendix D. The models were estimated using the xtivreg2 command in Stata 14. RMSEA = root mean square error of adjustment.

*Coefficients significant at the $p < .05$ level.

this change is associated with short-term political factors including net evaluations of the parties and the president. Notably, we are able to show that this relationship holds even after accounting for measurement error and that our findings are robust to several alternative modeling strategies. On the contrary, we show that changes in latent party identification are neither rapid nor universal. When party identification changes, it changes slowly, and for many people it does not change at all. Thus, party identification is not so much the "unmoved mover" as the "very slow mover" or perhaps the "infrequent mover" of public opinion. Thus, while party identification may be socialized as an indelible identity for many Americans, the results suggest that for others, changes in responses are not merely artifacts of short-run, arbitrary feelings. Indeed, true change occurs when considering shifts in the major identification categories, not simply as shifts between strong and not-strong identifiers.

These findings echo scholars of *aggregate* PID who have long argued that party identification is neither a simple evaluation of the parties nor an immutable identity, but rather a bit of both (Erikson, MacKuen, and Stimson 2002, 15). At the aggregate level, party identification is not static, but neither is it as responsive to short-run forces as, say, presidential approval reflecting heterogeneity in party identification change at the individual level. Thus, in a real sense, our results provide concrete micro-level foundations for the dynamics of macropartisanship (MacKuen, Erikson, and Stimson 1989).

In all, we believe that the results above represent the most comprehensive examination of individual-level

Table 7. Determinants of Individual-Level PID: Cross-Lagged Conditional ALT Model with Time-Invariant and Time-Varying Predictors.

Time-varying predictors of PID	
Net party evaluation _{t-1} → PID _t	-0.059* (0.009)
Presidential approval _{t-1} → PID _t	-0.062* (0.013)
Economy _{t-1} → PID _t	-0.010 (0.012)
PID _{t-1} → PID _t	0.178* (0.025)
Time-varying predictors of net party evaluation	
PID _{t-1} → net party evaluation _t	-0.218* (0.009)
Net party evaluation _{t-1} → net party evaluation _t	0.671* (0.011)
Time-varying predictors of presidential approval	
PID _{t-1} → presidential approval _t	-0.129* (0.007)
Presidential approval _{t-1} → presidential approval _t	0.731* (0.011)
Time-varying predictors of economic evaluations	
PID _{t-1} → economy _t	-0.051* (0.004)
Economy _{t-1} → economy _t	0.635* (0.011)
CFI	0.835
RMSEA	0.039
χ^2	19,692.53
df	3,783
N	2,783

Standard errors are in parentheses. Additional model parameters are suppressed for clarity. PID = party identification; CFI = comparative fit indices; RMSEA = root mean square error of adjustment.

*Coefficients significant at the $p < .05$ level.

party identification change to date. Nonetheless, there are limitations to the present study and opportunities for future research. First, we argue that party identification changes as a consequence of changes in net party evaluations and presidential approval. As noted above, we cannot experimentally manipulate these factors and must rely on observational approaches that are necessarily imperfect for identifying causal effects. Second, TAPS covers a limited, tranquil period in American politics so that aggregate party evaluations and party identification changed little during the period. We believe that a longer study that encompasses more dramatic political events is likely to demonstrate stronger effects. Finally, panel data collected over a few years cannot capture either the life-long social process or lifelong accumulation of party evaluations, and it is possible that panels spanning longer periods may reach somewhat different conclusions.

Despite these limitations, the findings reported here should stimulate new explorations of the microlevel

foundations of party identification dynamics. For instance, we have shown that net party evaluations and presidential approval are key drivers of party identification, but what factors are most critical in shaping these evaluations in turn? Future research should also examine additional factors that affect party identification stability, and particularly the role of political sophistication.

Finally, our research suggests additional questions that we may be able to answer given even longer term panels. One avenue of future research using panels could explore how party identification changes in response to critical life events and changes in one's social and geographic environment. Likewise, an even longer term panel than we use here might be able to examine how changes in party control of the various branches of government moderates the relationship between, say, economic evaluations and partisan identity.²⁴ Scholars might also take up the question of how much systematic change is needed to, for example, affect election outcomes or long-term partisan balances at the national level. In general, the robustness of our results suggests that investigation into this longrunning debate should be expanded and evaluated.

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Notes

1. A smaller literature explores stability in the degree to which German respondents are "inclined" to one of the two major parties (e.g., Neundorff, Stegmüller, and Scotto 2011).
2. Research also suggests that varying levels of education and political attentiveness are related to varying levels of stability in partisan identification (e.g., Bollen and Curran 2005; Carsey and Layman 2006). While we do not formalize hypotheses regarding these relationships in the main text, we discuss such phenomena in online Appendix F.
3. Panelists can miss some months and subsequently reenter the panel. Poststratification weights for this analysis were constructed based on the 2011 current population survey (CPS) population parameters. Weights were constructed using iterative raking and trimming (maximum weight = 5) using level of education, metro area, income, ethnicity, Internet access, age, and gender.
4. We have also estimated parallel analyses using a three-point scale that largely confirm the main findings from those using a seven-point scale. These results may be found in online Appendix Section L.
5. In "Alternative Analyses: Possible Endogeneity" section

and the appendices, we consider additional approaches including cross-lagged models, instrumental variables models, and fixed effects models. In all cases, the results conform with those presented in the main text.

6. For identification purposes, at least two of these λ parameters must be constrained to be a constant while, in principle, the remaining λ parameters can be freely estimated. In practice, we found that this did not improve model fit, lead to problems with convergence, and made interpretation more difficult.
7. Formally, this is indicated below by estimating a different $\rho_{y_t, y_{t-1}}$ coefficient for each wave of the panel. In Table SI-15 we show results from a model where we constrain this autoregressive process to be constant across waves, which is more similar to how previous scholars have modeled party identification in panel settings (e.g., Carsey and Layman 2006). These results are substantively identical to those we report in the main text.
8. For the sake of brevity, we suppress the expression of the correlated errors in model 2, although they are depicted in Figure 2. Full model results will be provided in the replication archive at the time of publication.
9. The American Panel Survey (TAPS) sample finds Independents and partisan leaners slightly decrease in the months leading up to an election, a trend that dissipates almost immediately post election. We examined party identification change using only waves leading up to the 2012 election. The results were analogous to those reported here.
10. All panelists complete a pre-panel survey before entering the panel. Obviously, the timing of this interview varies depending on when respondents joined.
11. All models were estimated with maximum likelihood estimation with robust standard errors using MPlus. The autoregressive terms are shown in online Appendix B. As we would expect, we find that all estimates of the lagged party identification effect on current party identification are significant in both frameworks. Note that the magnitude of these coefficients increases significantly for later waves, indicating increasing deviations away from a simple linear trend over time.
12. Note that these fit statistics penalizes for model complexity (Bollen 1989).
13. We also considered two alternative specifications of this model. First, in online Appendix I, we consider a model where we allow the time-varying factors to have a different effect on party identification in panel waves that occurred near the national elections in 2012 and 2014 (here, October 2012 and September 2014). This is designed to account for the fact that partisan identify may be more strongly primed in these periods (Gelman and King 1993). In online Appendix SI-17, we duplicate the results above but exclude our measure of socialization (self-reported party identification at age 18). In both cases, our main findings are unchanged.
14. We consider a white female respondent with some college education and a household income over \$100,000 who reported being a Republican at age 18.
15. Specifically, we subtract three categories from the observed LNPE reported in each wave. This decrease does not move any observation outside of the range of possible values (−4, 4).
16. These estimates are from model 1 above. Specifically, we estimate the latent trajectories of all respondents and place their estimated party identification in the first wave where we can generate these estimates at the point (0, 0).
17. As above, we focus here on panelists for whom party identification could be estimated in at least five waves. As the model requires a lagged value, this requires panelists to have responded to at least six waves.
18. We also find significant differences in party identification stability with respect to education and political interest. Results may be found in online Appendix F.
19. We acknowledge the limitation of a socialization measure based on recall. In this way, the longitudinal studies of Jennings and Niemi (1981) are at a great advantage.
20. One potential critique to our findings might be our use of a seven-point scale of party identification rather than a stricter three-point scale. To address this critique, we replicate our main analysis using both a three-point continuous and three-point categorical scale. Our results are largely confirmed with this exercise and may be found in online Appendix Section L.
21. Additional results, including first-stage estimates for the instruments can be found in online Appendix D.
22. Carsey and Layman (2006) also include an AR(1) process for the time-varying covariates such that, for instance, net party approval at time $t-1$ affects net party approval at time t . As in our main results, we take the more agnostic approach of simply allowing for correlated errors between covariates across waves. Full results for this model will be included in our replication archive at the time of publication.
23. Note that the model fit statistics for this model fail to meet standard thresholds indicating acceptable fit. For this reason, we view these results as yet another robustness test for our findings but do not rest our conclusions strongly on this analysis.
24. We looked for shifts in these patterns in our study when control of the House and Senate shifted, but were unable to find any reliable results.

Supplemental Material

Supplemental materials for this article are available with the manuscript on the *Political Research Quarterly* (PRQ) website. Materials for replication are available at taps.wustl.edu or patricktucker.org.

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